

KS₃: MEDIEVAL ENGLAND & THE STRUGGLE FOR POWER (1066–1485)

COURSE TEXTBOOK & TEXTBOOK

Enquiry: How did power shift in Medieval England?

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L1: 1066: Why did three men claim one throne, and how did William win?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain why there was a succession crisis in 1066 and evaluate the claims of the three rivals.
- ☐ Analyze the sequence of events leading up to the Battle of Hastings.
- ☐ Evaluate the reasons for William's victory at the Battle of Hastings.

On **5 January 1066**, the King of England, **Edward the Confessor**, died. Because he and his wife had never had any children, there was no clear heir to take his place. To make matters worse, Anglo-Saxon customs about who should become king were not clear, and over his 24-year reign, Edward had made promises about the succession to different people at different times.

This created a massive power vacuum, and three powerful rivals stepped forward to claim the throne.

The Claimant	Who was he?	What was his claim (justification)?
Harold Godwinson	The Earl of Wessex and the most powerful, wealthy nobleman in England. A brave warrior and brother-in-law to the dead king.	The Deathbed Promise: He claimed that as Edward lay dying, the King nominated Harold to succeed him. The Witan (the council of English lords) backed him, and he was crowned the very next day.
William, Duke of Normandy	The ambitious, ruthless ruler of Normandy (modern-day northern France). A brilliant and highly experienced military commander.	The Old Promise and the Broken Oath: He claimed Edward had promised him the throne back in 1051. He also claimed that Harold Godwinson had visited Normandy in 1064 and sworn a sacred oath on holy relics to help William become king. He got the support of the Pope , turning his invasion into a religious crusade.
Haralad Hardrada	The legendary, feared Viking King of Norway. One of the most famous and brutal warriors in Europe.	The Viking Agreement: His claim was based on an old, past agreement made between previous kings of Norway and England. If one died childless, the other would inherit both kingdoms. To make his claim stronger, he was joined by Tostig , King Harold's angry, exiled brother.

Q1. Task 1: The Claimants' Pitch (Group Battle) Imagine you are an adviser to the Witan (the council of English lords) in January 1066. Write a short persuasive speech (3-4 sentences) for **ONE** of the three claimants (Harold, William, or Hardrada) convincing the lords why they should choose your man to be King. Hint: Make sure you use their specific historical evidence (like Harold's deathbed promise, William's holy oath, or Hardrada's old Viking treaty) to make your case!

King Harold Godwinson knew he was surrounded. He spent the summer waiting on the south coast with his army, expecting William to sail over from France. But the wind was blowing from the north, trapping William's ships in port.

Then, disaster struck. **Harald Hardrada's Viking fleet of 300 ships landed in the north of England.**

- **Battle of Gate Fulford (20 September):** The Vikings met the northern English earls, Edwin and Morcar, and absolutely destroyed their armies, leaving the north wide open.
- **Battle of Stamford Bridge (25 September):** Hearing of the invasion, King Harold made an incredible military move. He marched his army **190 miles north in just five days**. He took the Vikings completely by surprise. In a bloody battle, both Harald Hardrada and Tostig were killed. Harold had won an outstanding victory.

But as Harold celebrated, devastating news arrived: **the wind in the south had changed**. William's invasion fleet had landed at Pevensey.

Q2. Task 2: The Exhaustion Timeline (Why Timing was Everything) Historians argue that William was incredibly lucky with the weather in September 1066. 1. Calculate the days: How many days did Harold have between fighting the Vikings at Stamford Bridge (25 Sept) and fighting the Normans at Hastings (14 Oct)? 2. Explain the impact: Write a short explanation of how the timing of the two invasions left Harold's army at a massive disadvantage before the Battle of Hastings even started.

Q3. Task 5: Tension Timeline Draw a line graph mapping King Harold's stress levels day-by-day throughout September and October 1066. Label key events such as waiting for the wind, hearing about the Viking invasion, winning at Stamford Bridge, and the Norman landing.

Harold's exhausted army had to turn around and march **nearly 300 miles back down south** to meet the Normans. When the two armies finally met at Senlac Hill near Hastings, it was a battle between two very different styles of warfare.

Phase 1: The Anglo-Saxon Advantage

Harold positioned his troops at the very top of a steep ridge, forming a tightly packed, heavy **shield wall**. William's archers fired uphill, but their arrows bounced harmlessly off the wooden shields. William ordered his heavy cavalry to charge up the damp, steep hill, but the English swung massive battleaxes, slicing through Norman horses and riders. The shield wall held firm.

Phase 2: The Rumour and the Feigned Retreat

As the death toll grew, panic spread through the Norman lines. A rumour swept the army that Duke William had been killed. The Breton soldiers on the left began to flee in terror, and some Saxon soldiers broke their own lines to chase them down the hill.

William acted quickly to save his army. **He pushed back his helmet so his men could see his face, shouting that he was still alive**. The regrouped Normans turned on the Saxons who had chased them and slaughtered them.

Seeing how easily the Saxons were tempted to leave their high ground, William ordered his men forward to perform a **"feigned retreat"**. The Normans charged, fought briefly, and then pretended to run away in panic. The Saxons fell for the trick twice. They broke their invincible shield wall to run down the hill in pursuit, only to be surrounded and cut to pieces by the Norman cavalry.

Phase 3: The Fatal Shower and the King's Death

With the Saxon shield wall broken open, William ordered his archers to fire high into the air so that a rain

of arrows poured down on the unprotected Saxons from above.

Late in the afternoon, surrounded by his bodyguard, **King Harold was killed**. Whether he was hit in the eye by an arrow or cut down by Norman knights is a mystery. With their leader dead, the surviving Anglo-Saxon soldiers panicked and fled into the surrounding forests. **William, Duke of Normandy, had won the Battle of Hastings**.

Q4. Task 3: Hastings Tactical Analysis (How the Battle was Won) Copy and complete the flow diagram below to show how the battle shifted in William's favour. [1. Saxon Shield Wall holds firm on the high ground] ⬇ [2. Rumour spreads that William is _____. William removes his _____ to prove he is alive.] ⬇ [3. The Cunning Plan: William orders a "_____ retreat" to trick the Saxons down the hill.] ⬇ [4. Saxon Shield Wall is broken. Archers fire _____, and King _____ is killed.]

Q5. Task 4: The Turning Point Debate (Evaluation) Look at the list of reasons why William won: - William's clever tactics (the feigned retreat) - Harold's mistakes (letting his men chase the retreating Normans) - Bad luck for Harold (having to fight two invasions at opposite ends of the country) - William's leadership (keeping his men motivated and organized) Write a brief paragraph arguing which of these was the single most important reason William won the throne. Use evidence from your notes to justify your choice!

L2: Castles, Terror, and the Domesday Book: How did William control England?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

☐ Understand the core concepts of Castles, Terror, and the Domesday Book: How did William control England?

Placeholder content for Castles, Terror, and the Domesday Book: How did William control England?

L3: Crown vs Church: Why did Henry II clash with Thomas Becket?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

☐ Understand the core concepts of Crown vs Church: Why did Henry II clash with Thomas Becket?

Placeholder content for Crown vs Church: Why did Henry II clash with Thomas Becket?

L4: Magna Carta (1215): A triumph of liberty or a selfish baronial power grab?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand the core concepts of Magna Carta (1215): A triumph of liberty or a selfish baronial power grab?

Placeholder content for Magna Carta (1215): A triumph of liberty or a selfish baronial power grab?

L5: 1348: How did the Black Death shatter medieval social order?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand the core concepts of 1348: How did the Black Death shatter medieval social order?

Placeholder content for 1348: How did the Black Death shatter medieval social order?

L6: 1381: Why did the Peasants revolt, and did they achieve anything?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand the core concepts of 1381: Why did the Peasants revolt, and did they achieve anything?

Placeholder content for 1381: Why did the Peasants revolt, and did they achieve anything?

L7: Assessment: How powerful was a medieval monarch?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand the core concepts of Assessment: How powerful was a medieval monarch?

Placeholder content for Assessment: How powerful was a medieval monarch?

